Leadership Tool: Building an Effective Team Starts with Building Relationships During the Interview

Building an effective team is one of the most important activities a leader engages in to lead to success. The creation of an effective team leads to collective outputs that exceed what any one individual can contribute. This collective output not only accelerates the achievement of organizational/team goals but also cultivates a culture of trust and empowerment, which boosts moral and employee satisfaction. *Sounds amazing right?* Well, all of this, especially the creation of effective teams begins with the interview process. This initial step is not only about assessing an individual for technical skills/experience but is about identifying the next team member whose values, work style, and aspirations align with the team or organization's goals.

Additionally, the interviewing process sets the tone for the team's culture and how individuals on the team perceive the leader. In all stages of joining a group/team, this introduction is critical to communicate the values and expectations of the group/team. Interviewing is no different. This is the first exposure the candidate has to the new team and is consistently shaping their perception of what it is like to work with and contribute to the team. The interview process is not just about selecting someone to fill a role or complete job duties but is a chance to lay the groundwork for the incoming employee's integration and success within the team. By prioritizing best practices for interviewing, leaders can significantly improve their ability to build effective teams that are both skilled technically and deeply committed to the collective success of the team. In the following article we will look at some advanced best practices to establish relationships during the interview process and build highly effective teams.

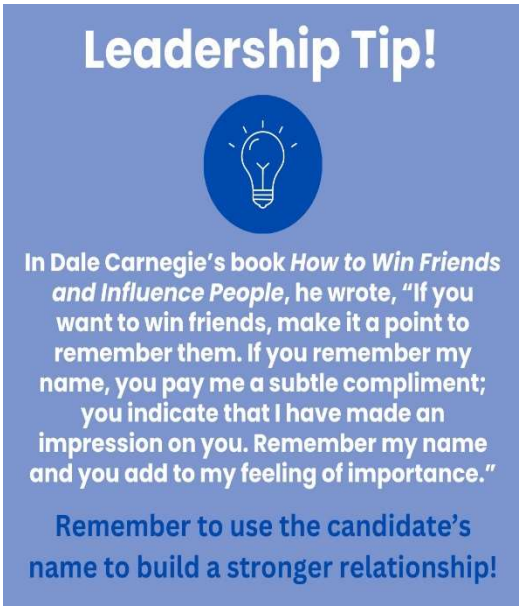
First Impression: Building a Relationship

In the initial moments and throughout the first interaction with someone, individuals often form lasting opinions about one another based on several different factors, including communication style, body language, and mutual respect. This initial perception is hard to alter once set, making the effort (especially during the first impression of an interview) to make a positive first impression especially important to consider. Overall, a positive first impression can create an atmosphere of openness and meaningful conversation during the interview that will carry on to the first weeks of employment. The following are some best practices to consider when building this initial first impression to build a strong relationship with the candidate.

- **Open Communication and Transparency**: As is true in any relationship, both trust and respect are key to the success of the relationship formed in the interview process. Initially, this trust and respect is formed by the candidate when they perceive a leader

utilizing open communication and transparency to establish the relationship and move the interview process forward. It is important, even before starting the interview questions, that a leader provides the candidate with detailed information about the interview process. When communicating the process, let employees know how long the interview will last, how the questions will flow, when they can ask questions, and a timeline for decision making concerning the position. Additionally, this is a great time to provide a comprehensive overview of the job responsibilities, the team dynamics, and the company's culture.

- **Take an Active Interest**: Another key to the first impression and building the foundation of an effective relationship is to take an active interest in the candidate. All too often, those leading the interview will kick the interview off with questions in a rapid style, one right after the other. The candidate, feeling a great deal of anxiety, will try to answer (often with brief responses) just to keep up. Before you know it, the interviewer has asked all the questions, and the interview is over. Instead, take your time. If, through your open, transparent communication you said the interview will last 60 minutes, then it should last 60 minutes. If you suggested it will last 30 minutes, then stick to that time. This carries a great deal of weight in the mind of the candidate both in terms of respect but also in their perception of the interviewer's interest in them.



Additionally, being flexible in asking your questions is important. Find opportunities to follow up on something the candidate said to ask a more in-depth question. For example, if they mentioned integrity as a personal value or advanced knowledge in a sales tool, ask a bit more about what they meant or what they know. This will show that you are both listening and have an interest. Another way to show interest is taking notes. While the notes do not have to be detailed and should be about the question asked (or to use the interviewing rubric), taking notes communicates to the candidate that you are actively involved with the interview (not to mention they will certainly help you after the interview when making a decision).

- **Leading By Example**: As in all things associated with leadership, leading by example in the interview setting is important. Leaders can set a powerful precedent either purposefully or by the lack of action demonstrated in this context. Showing up to an interview late communicates that the interview is not as important as other commitments. On the other hand, showing up prior to and being prepared lets both the candidate and others in the interview know that it is critically important to build strong relationships. Additionally, when leaders demonstrate qualities such as respect, transparency, and

fairness in the interview process, they communicate these as core values of the organization. Finally, leading by example in an interview suggests, to both the candidate and others, that leadership is not just about directing others but embodies the qualities that inspire and motivate excellence in teams.

As the saying goes, "you only get one chance to make a first impression." One of the best ways to build out an effective team is to utilize the interview process to communicate what it is like to work with you and the team. By setting the expectation of building relationships in the interview process you are letting the candidate and others know what values are most important to you and the company.

Balancing Similarities and Differences

A part of being an effective leader and building an outstanding team, especially when discussing the process of interviewing, is the ability to handle competing demands. For example, it is critical that leaders are able to select candidates that add to the team and culture not detract from it. This is done by selecting a candidate that has similar values, motivations, and interests in achieving team success. On the other hand, diversity of ideas, knowledge, and competencies are necessary for a high performing team. So how can these competing demands be addressed by leaders?

- **Keeping Values** The importance of a leader selecting a candidate with values that align with both the leader and the organization cannot be overstated, as it ensures the candidate's success and cohesion with the team. These shared values foster a harmonious work environment, enhance job satisfaction, and strengthen their commitment to both team and organizational goals. Additionally, similar values lead to higher levels of loyalty and lower levels of turnover. Effective leaders are clear on their values and the values of the organization to be able to ask questions to assess whether a candidate's values align to ensure fit within the culture. This strategic, value-driven approach to hiring is essential to navigate challenges and achieve collective objectives with a sense of unity and purpose.

- **Addressing Unconscious Bias**: While ensuring fit between the candidate and the team, especially when it comes to values is important, it is also important for leaders to check their unconscious bias during the interview process to ensure the best candidate is selected. Too often leaders favor certain candidates because of their similarities to the leader and/or other reasons unrelated to job competence or potential fit. While this undermines the fairness of the hiring process, it also limits the organization's ability to attract and retain a diverse and talented workforce.

  To effectively check unconscious bias during the interview process, leaders should utilize a structured interview guide with rubric to guarantee a standard set of questions for all candidates. This guide helps to minimize subjective judgments and ensures consistency in the hiring process. Additionally, leaders should regularly review hiring data for patterns that may indicate bias, such as a lack of general diverse characteristics in selected candidates. Finally, leaders can benefit from training on unconscious bias to become more aware of their preconceptions and learn strategies to mitigate them. Ultimately, checking personal bias is an ongoing process that requires leaders to be introspective, open to feedback, and committed to fostering an inclusive environment where every candidate has a fair chance to succeed.

Leaders who can consider both the importance of values and the need for diversity in their team will be more successful in building an effective team. However, this does take time, self-awareness, and constant reflection. Each time a leader conducts an interview is an opportunity to utilize these skills to ensure they are selecting the candidate that will continue to build an effective team.

After the Interview

One truly best practice activity that effective leaders use after interviewing a candidate is to send a thoughtful post-interview follow-up email. This sends the candidate a distinct message that you are the type of leader that goes out of their way to build/maintain positive relationships and truly respects people's time. The following is a template of an email you could send out (it will just take two minutes) to all candidates you interview, whether they get the job or not. If they do get the job, they will have an incredible first impression of you and your ability to build relationships. If they do not get the job, they will still be left with a tremendously positive experience and will be more likely to share this positive experience with others (increasing your/organization reputation and the likelihood of top talent applying for future positions).

Post-interview Follow-up Email

Subject: Thank You for Interviewing with Us, [Candidate's Name]

Dear [Candidate's Name],

I wanted to extend my sincere thanks for taking the time to interview with us for the [Position Name] position yesterday. It was a pleasure learning about your experiences and discussing how your skills and aspirations align with our goals at [Company Name].

We are currently in the process of interviewing other candidates and expect to make a decision by [specific time frame]. We will keep you updated on the status of your application throughout this period. In the meantime, should you have any questions or need further information, please do not hesitate to reach out.

Regardless of the outcome, I was impressed by your [specific quality, experience, or skill discussed in the interview], and I am confident that you will continue to achieve great success in your career. Thank you once again for your interest in joining [Company Name] and for the opportunity to meet with you. We appreciate the effort you have put into this process.

Best Regards,

[Your Name]

[Your Position]

[Company Name]

[Contact Information]

Conclusion

By establishing a rapport with candidates from the first interaction, leaders not only enhance the company's appeal to top talent but also gain deeper insights into candidates' personalities, values, and potential fit within the team. This relational approach fosters an atmosphere of trust and openness, encouraging candidates to be more authentic in their responses and interactions. Consequently, leaders are better equipped to make informed hiring decisions that contribute to a cohesive, motivated, and dynamic team, ultimately driving the organization's success and innovation. Building relationships during the interview process thus emerges as a critical skill for leaders aiming to cultivate a productive and harmonious workplace.